



than stone carvings, particularly those of the celestial dancers. The temple is dedicated to the four-armed Lord Vishnu. More than 100 ft (30 m) high, it originally boasted a tapering, curvilinear tower, or *shikhar*. The building is surrounded by four smaller temples.

Krak des Chevaliers

Location Homs, Syria

Krak des Chevaliers (“Castle of the Kurds”) was rebuilt in 1144 by the Knights Hospitallers following the First Crusade. It is one of the most memorable and formidable of all medieval castles, and one of the best preserved. It was built on a natural, craglike stronghold, although the nature of the site dictated the slightly irregular layout. It occupies an area of 256,000 square ft (23,800 square m). Following a further stage of building in the 13th century, it

became a concentric castle with two tower-studded defensive walls—one outer and one inner—that made it essentially impregnable. Any parts of the inner wall thought to be relatively vulnerable were reinforced by sloping sections, or “glacis,” in parts more than 82 ft (25 m) thick.

Kalyan Minaret

Location Bukhara, Uzbekistan

Completed in 1127, the Kalyan Minaret, meaning “great minaret,” is a structure of exceptional simplicity and remarkable elegance. It is a 154-ft- (47-m-) high, free-standing tower of golden bricks that tapers slightly as it climbs before flaring outward at its summit. The diameter of the base is 30 ft (9 m) and that of the summit is 20 ft (6 m). The body of the tower is banded with 12 rows of elegantly incised geometrical decorations. Just below the more elaborately carved rotunda at the summit is the sole touch of color: a glazed frieze of pale blue, with inscriptions from the Qur’an. Sixteen arches, from where the faithful are called to prayer, circle the rotunda. The minaret stands in the courtyard of the 16th-century blue-domed Kalyan Mosque.

Summer Palace

Location Beijing, China

Beijing’s Summer Palace is more than a palace. Grouped around a man-made lake, it is a series of gardens, lakes, and ornamental buildings in a landscaped park that spreads over 1.1 square miles (2.9 square km). Although there had been an imperial garden in this area since the mid-12th century, it was in the 18th century, during the Qing dynasty, that the gardens took on their present form. They almost form a microcosm of subsequent Chinese history. A place of luxury, the Summer Palace was repeatedly looted and largely destroyed between 1860 and 1900. It was only in 1953 that restoration work began.

► INTRICATE DETAILING
ON THE WALLS OF THE
KALYAN MINARET

